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Houston Person

Part II

Houston Person is a tenor saxophonist who is equally comfortable in a jazz quartet or with an organ based trio that leans towards R&B. Born in 1934, Houston grew up in South Carolina and was fortunate to play with future jazz greats Eddie Harris and Cedar Walton while in the military. He later attended the Hartt School of Music and toured with a number of organ trios. Houston has recorded numerous albums as a leader and enjoys a longtime collaboration with singer Etta Jones.

Mr. Person was interviewed by Monk Rowe in Clinton, New York on October 2, 1998.

MR: We are filming today at the Hamilton College Jazz Archive, and it's a great pleasure for me to have a second chance to talk to tenor saxophonist and band leader Houston Person.

HP: Hi.

MR: Hi. Welcome again.

HP: Thank you, I'm glad to be here.

MR: Making a — it's fortunate for Utica jazz lovers that you're appearing in Utica. We don't get men of your stature that often up here, and so we'll be looking forward to tomorrow night.

HP: Oh I'm looking forward to it too. I've never been to Utica.

MR: Well it had its day as a jazz center for a while. We do our best up here. But you're a guy who's had 75 albums at last count.

HP: Something like that.

MR: Soon to be 76 you said. Tell me about your recent thing that's coming out.

HP: This is an album of standards, mostly ballads, and on it I'm stressing the melody, how strong the melodies are, with not too much emphasis on improvisation. But the improvisation is subtle. But I'm just stressing the melody and the strongness of songs from the great American songbook. Probably most of them you would consider, people would say have been over-done, but I wanted to do this set of songs, it really stressed a lot of content and melody.

MR: When you say that it reminds me of something off this album that I'll play a bit of when you did "As Time Goes By" that you treat that melody with so much care.

HP: Oh yeah. I love the melody.

MR: When you do that on this particular album does it make for shorter cuts?

HP: That's one thing about this is that I went back to the concept of doing it as if they were 78's, so we went from anywhere from 4-5 minutes. There's a track of "Laura" that is a little extended but the rest of them are in that time range. I've been trying to stress melody, keep simple, and not be too long.

MR: Do you find that that's something that you feel the jazz audience needs these days? To have a musician keep the songs perhaps a little shorter so that you don't alienate anybody?

HP: Well not necessarily. I think that if you don't have anything to say for so long and trying to get it together on stage, I don't go there. You should know what you're going to say when you get up there and get it over with. So if you go back and listen to those 78's, that Charlie Parker and Dizzy and Miles did, you'll see that their solos were short and they did it all. I mean those things are amazing. And you try to play some of those solos, transcribe them, and you can't. And they were the ones that were qualified to take long solos, and they didn't.

MR: That's a great point. And it's interesting how the technology has allowed other things to happen but perhaps not all that positive. I mean you have — to do a CD now, you're expected to do almost an hour of music.

HP: Well the way I feel is you know with technology, you know, things don't necessarily get better. Because a lot of people rely on it too much. And computers still break down. Now you've got people who can't add without a calculator. So I don't rely on technology. I mean I still like to add. My brother and I we always, when we check the ledger books for our little business in South Carolina, I still add, you know, and subtract, manually.

MR: Trust yourself more.

HP: Yeah, but I enjoy it. I enjoy the thrill of doing those things. But so with music, a lot of people now use music, well it's really worked against a lot of musicians, starting with the LP. Because instead of adding more tunes they just stretched the ones they were already playing. So I'm trying to add more melodies, more tunes, and still edit and keep the songs at a reasonable length. Now if you get something going and you've got it going then say it. But I like that 78 feel, the way you get in there and get out.

MR: Who did you buy when you were young, that you were listening to, and were they on 78's at that time?

HP: Oh yeah, yeah. Dinah Washington, Buddy Johnson, Stan Kenton. I was in the south. Yeah, Stan Kenton, Dizzy Gillespie. Just about everybody — Lester Young — they were all on 78's. And then the LP came.

MR: Who in particular on tenor did you feel that you might have been influenced by?

HP: Well I liked everybody really, starting with Illinois Jacquet. And it's funny, when you're out of New York you get a better feel of what really — see being in the south I got all

those different influences, Gospel, blues — so I liked Tom Archia, you know, the guy who worked with Wynonie Harris, and then there was Johnny Griffin with Hot Lips, and other guys played in R&B things. Willis Jackson. And then I liked Hank Mobley, just everybody, I liked everybody. But now my initial influence I would say would have to be probably Illinois Jacquet. But I liked Lester Young, Gene Ammons, and I liked Stan Getz and I like Warne Marsh a lot, and I liked another saxophone player that used to be from Newark, I never knew what happened to him, Joe Holiday. And another one of my big influences was Percy France, he used to play with Bill Doggett in the organ groups. So there was all kinds of influences out there.

MR: People seem to associate you a lot with organ groups, but that's only part of what you did.

HP: Yeah. I like organ groups, I like piano groups. I like anything that's swinging and is bluesy.

MR: Okay. It's early in the interview, but I'm going to ask you a hard question. You said you like anything that swings. Can you define that?

HP: No.

MR: Okay. That was a short answer.

HP: No. Swing — well to me swing contributes to an element in jazz that has been left out now. That's why we have problems, is the element of dance and it makes the body move, and makes your feet move and makes you respond. That's what swing is, I guess the little thing your body is — you go, if you shake your head or whatever you do, but there's a certain swing, an element that makes the body want to move. And now when you go to hear jazz you've got to sit still and you can't dance, you can't have fun.

MR: Yeah or somebody across from you will tell you shhh, shhh.

HP: Yes. It's really weird.

MR: Well if tomorrow night let's say you're in this jazz club in Utica, how would you feel if people started to get up and dance?

HP: I'd be happy.

MR: Would you?

HP: Yeah. To me that's a part of it. That makes it complete. That's why when you're playing in a jazz club and people are leaving like at eleven o'clock, I'll say like, "where are you going?" "Oh we're going somewhere where we can dance." Now years ago it wasn't that way. You know, you'd dance.

MR: Do you think that it's because we have elevated jazz to almost a highbrow art form?

HP: Yeah. It's become an elitist — it's become elite. A lot of people don't really understand it you know. It's a passing fad or diversion. But well it's like what classical music became, and then classical music had problems, it became the same way. Even like in the, you

know like Ludwig in Bavaria. You'd have a composer write a tune and just his friends come to hear it. They'd sit there in a two thousand seat theater with about twenty people, his cronies would listen to it. The people couldn't hear it. I don't mean to call names, but this is what royalty did. They would give chamber music, and I guess that's where "chamber" the term came from.

MR: Small venue.

HP: Yeah. Very small venue. And then that became sort of elitist. But the people will always find an alternate music.

MR: If they're not getting what they want, they're going to go somewhere else.

HP: Yeah. So when they couldn't dance, they can't rock. Rock 'n roll and then they started dancing. Because you can't kill the human spirit. They'll find a way. The same way they cut music out of the schools, and bond issues and people wouldn't vote to train kids, and then you had people just find a little turntable and they'd start scratching and making their own rhythm and then you've got rap. So the people will always find a way. And then you wonder why so many people like it — because they haven't been exposed to anything else. You know, you keep it in the parlors. And it's almost parlor music in some places.

MR: Do you think institutions like Lincoln Center Jazz are good or bad for music overall?

HP: Well nothing is bad. I mean nothing is bad. Even if you're creating music for 20 or 30 people or for a private soiree, nothing's bad. I'd just like to see more music in the schools. That's where it all starts. Like we used to have the music appreciation courses and you know, where you just got a little whiff of music, you didn't have to be a virtuoso, just know the alternatives. And that's what we had, we had music appreciation classes in early school. And then if you wanted to be in the band they had an instrument for you, no matter how broken it was, they had one for you. And there are a lot of schools that do that but there's just not enough. It doesn't reach — especially in the inner cities. Now they're even trying to cut out athletic programs. So you really stymie childrens' creative ability when they don't have any artistic things. But still I don't know how the parents let the administrations get away with it, when they pay taxes.

MR: I know education is a big issue for you, central to your philosophy. Do you get involved with — your son is at college now is that right?

HP: Yeah, my step-son, yeah.

MR: And does he seem to be finding his way in his college life? Are you happy with what he's doing?

HP: Yeah. But he's not — he likes music, I think eventually he will wind up with some of that. And I have a daughter who wants to be a promoter.

MR: She can start with you, right?

HP: Yes. They are sort of interested. But they are going their own way, which is fine with me. But back to Lincoln Center, I think they're doing a wonderful job there. And especially with the kids programs. And they do as much as they can and they've got a forceful guy down there, Wynton, he keeps on fighting. And Jon Faddis, I like what he's doing too. So there are two guys who are really making big contributions. And they have people who they're responsible to. But they do what they can, and they do some wonderful things too. They really expose a lot of — really get into more of a concert type thing, which it can be. That's not what I was talking about earlier. Because Wynton wrote a ballet too. So he's into dance too. So dance is a very big part of this music.

MR: I think I saw a thing in the *New York Times* recently that they had done a concert with a dance venue — people were doing the Swing dance out —

HP: Oh Lincoln Center, oh man it was great. I went down to hear Illinois Jacquet's band. And that's great. Now I was looking at thousands of people dance. I mean and I was saying to myself, I was talking to Bob Porter and I said, "this is so simple, to really bring jazz back into the mainstream of things. Just let the people dance. Let the people participate." Because usually what you wind up with is people looking at somebody indulge themselves, and they can't indulge. It's like a lot of people have this feeling, you know, you're on the outside looking in.

MR: Yeah.

HP: And there's this guy just playing, and you're looking. Now do you feel like dancing, or clapping even? You can't. So I can understand people when they say well I'm going over here where I can have some fun. Because that's where it came from.

MR: Well you mention Illinois. He was kind of a bridge almost between into rhythm and blues and really a lot of theatrics.

HP: Oh yeah.

MR: Did people, did fellow musicians look askance at that kind of showboating thing?

HP: Well I don't think so. It was just, to me it was having fun with the music. Because these guys were some of the greatest guys, musicians in the world we're talking about — Dizzy, Gillespie, who was an entertainer. The greatest jazz musician of all, Louis Armstrong, was an entertainer. Lionel Hampton was an entertainer. See that element got lost somewhere. Miles Davis, in his own way, was an entertainer. All these guys. Mingus. You know, you look back you trace all the great guys, they were entertainers. Illinois Jacquet, you know with the Jazz at the Philharmonic. Count Basie's band, Duke Ellington—

MR: Talk about a showman, huh?

HP: Yeah, oh man, suave, elegant, and a showman. Even that was a part of the show. And these guys were top musicians, I mean the best. But they never lost sight of that audience.

They brought something, and there was no dignity lost, because who could have more dignity than Duke Ellington? So musicians, you're always going to have some people that are more serious and that's good too. I mean there's a place for — jazz is so big and so wide a range of feelings, you can have everything. Just know what's what. And there are times when there are concert situations, and there should be times there are dance situations. And I don't mean swing dancing, I mean with the ballet or Alvin Ailey, they do a lot of things with jazz. So there's —you go to hear any opera, there's always a ballet in it. These other genres don't discard the dance.

MR: I will quote your last interview. You said: "everything in balance."

HP: Yeah. That's right. And jazz is one of the musics that can do that. There's a place for everything. We just need to do more with the dance, and Lincoln Center did a great job with that this summer. They teach people, before the music starts you can go down and get lessons. So they've done a great thing. And then there are a lot of big bands creeping back into the scene.

MR: It seems to be. I keep seeing these little articles in the paper, swing is coming back.

HP: Oh yeah. And I heard Bob Mintzer's band this summer, it was great. So guys are out there.

MR: Well in your career as a recording musician, we mentioned you've recorded some seventy-some albums. Does the economics, has it changed a lot over the years? Trying to get records, out, keeping track of how they're doing? Has your relationship with record companies changed?

HP: I don't know. I have a good relationship with my record company, I've been there for ages. But I've been big and small. And I like small. The economics are different but I still like small because I can keep up with what's going on, I have control of my own production and if I need something somewhere they get it there immediately so I can keep a hands-on on what's going on.

MR: To get specific, do they give you X amount of dollars to work with when you make a recording, and then it's up to you to like keep within a budget?

HP: Yeah some companies do. But mine is so loosely — it's such a loose relationship there. We go over what we're going to do and I've been doing it so long I know how to do it and do it cost-wise I hope. Well I must be 'cause I wouldn't be there.

MR: That's right. You'd be looking elsewhere.

HP: Yeah.

MR: How long do you usually get to record a CD these days?

HP: I usually go right in and do it in one day, two days. I don't fool around with them. I go in and get it over with.

MR: You have to have a supporting cast who can keep it—

HP: Oh I know all my supporting cast, yes, that's why I can do it. Because in New York you know you've got the best, so I always get the best and I work with the best, so that's it for me.

MR: All right. I wanted to play a little cut off one of your fairly recent numbers, and ask you just a little bit about this.

[audio interlude: selection "Why Not" composed by Houston Person]

MR: That's some great stuff. Can you relate how this tune or most tunes come to you? How do you write?

HP: I don't know.

MR: Come on. You can tell me. You know, is it divine inspiration?

HP: Well yeah. Because I usually like to play other people's music and this one, it just came to me and it fit and there was a bridge I put in there, and I say, oh you never play your own stuff. Then I say why not? So that's where the title came from.

MR: I mean some people have told me that they would put on a tune even if it was a simple little blues head, because they would get some writer's royalties out of it.

HP: Right.

MR: But that doesn't seem to be your motivation.

HP: No. No I usually do other people's tunes. I like that. And I usually try to give these songs to other guys. But I'm glad I did this one. It won some awards. So I was happy about that.

MR: Do you sit at the piano and work?

HP: Nope. None of those things.

MR: Well there has to be a method for — you play [scats]. Now, where does the chord come from? You work with somebody else or you just hear the whole thing?

HP: Yeah. Everything's in minor.

MR: Yeah?

HP: Yeah.

MR: Okay.

HP: And what I really conceived it to be was a minor blues with a bridge. So that's the way I got it. And the bridge turned out to be pretty and melodic, so I like it.

MR: Yeah. And as we discussed before the cameras were rolling, it would lend itself to a big band arrangement.

HP: Yeah. A group in England recorded this and they recorded it with four horns. It came out real good.

MR: Yeah?

HP: But I'd like to hear it with a big band.

MR: I like the unison with the horns, and myself I'm always tempted to harmonize everything.

HP: Yeah.

MR: But the same lesson can be learned from Cannonball Adderley's group, which was one of my favorites, that most of the time just the way it was played was so—

HP: Yeah. I like the unison, yeah. It's stronger. I have to tell guys, lay off those thirds man. Just play it. But sometimes you're tempted, yeah, you're a musician and you want to show everything so you're tempted to do it. Sometimes I do it. And I know I shouldn't but I do it. It's funny how you know what not to do and you go ahead and do it anyway. And then you feel like an idiot. Why did I do it?

MR: That's the hardest lesson to learn though, what not to do.

HP: Yeah, right.

MR: I mean it's a hard thing to teach students for instance, what not to play.

HP: Oh yeah. And how to keep it simple. That's really hard. That's hard to old musicians.

MR: Oh boy. What's the New York City scene like for musicians like yourself these days. Is it worth making the effort to try to play in the city?

HP: Well I don't think city. I think universal. You've got to figure out where you want to make your home. Now I advise all young musicians or any musician, they have to come to New York, at least for a while. Because that's where the best is. And then you can go wherever you want to live. A lot of guys live a lot of different places, but they have been to New York and played with the best and got the experience of hard knocks, and then settle down and make a living. And you can make a living in the city playing music. I always tell guys you know, and an old musician told me once, you know because somebody always gives you advice, you know you say, "get a dark suit, a white shirt, a dark tie, be on time, learn the blues, 'Stardust" and 'Body and Soul' and you'll work." And I did that. And I worked. But basically music is so many fingers on it, so many ways you can make a living in it. But it's good to come to New York when you're young, and before you get a family and decide what you want to do. There's so many ways. I love music because there is — I don't think there's too many fields where you can be so many different things. I mean a promoter, producer, engineer, you know so many different things.

MR: After you got out of the service did you ever work non-musical jobs?

HP: No.

MR: You've been able to pretty much do it in music?

HP: Um hum.

MR: That's saying something.

HP: Yep. That's all I've done.

MR: And you started almost from the beginning having your own band.

HP: Yeah. I didn't work with any groups except I went with Johnny Hammond Smith's for about two years. And that was it. So I didn't have any — there was nothing visual.

Nobody knew who I was. And I just stuck it out. But if you get a wife, four girls to feed and a mortgage, you'll find a way. That's what happened.

MR: The motivation was definitely there.

HP: I had to keep myself saying now I want to play music. I've got to make this work. I've got to. So I got out and hustled.

MR: Hustling meant going to different clubs and getting your band booked in there—

HP: Yeah.

MR: I mean what kind of money would you have been making with your band — if you don't mind me getting personal — like in the early years?

HP: Scary. No money.

MR: Yeah.

HP: When I first started I realized that. I know the economics of jazz so I gave people offers they couldn't refuse to get in the door. And just kept building and building and building. And I was with Prestige Records and they were good to me, they stuck with me for a while and let me get my feet out there. And I had a lot of help on the way, a lot of people helped me. So that was really — and there are some good people in jazz. There are some cut throats, but hey, it's all fair, it balances out.

MR: It balances out.

HP: But even the cut throats are nice. And you've got your jazz characters, they'll always be there.

MR: Did it help to add the vocal element to your group from a working standpoint?

HP: Yeah. Well I wanted to have a band with a singer. That was my dream. Because when I used to see the bands come to the south, the bands would always have a singer. So it helped a lot. And having somebody with the stature of Etta wanting to be in the band was great. So it worked out fine. It's been a great help. It gives more balance for the presentation, so that's really helped. I hope to bring the group up here some day.

MR: To Hamilton? That sounds like a good idea.

HP: Yeah. That's your department.

MR: You said that on camera, so—

HP: I'm hustling a gig on camera.

MR: Well I hope to play with your band some day.

HP: I hope so.

MR: How do you guys, you and Etta work out, you both bring tunes to the table and say—

HP: No we don't work that way. Whatever she wants to do she does, whatever I want to do I do. And then we clash, and, "you take it a little while" and, "I'll take it a little while." And sometimes I'll suggest one that she should do and she'll say, "oh, no," then I'll play

it and she likes it. "Yeah I think I will." Then I like it. No it's a lot of fun, but we don't know, we don't do any of those things.

MR: You probably had to re-learn some standards in different keys for her voice?

HP: No not really. No. Well I mean I know all the keys anyway.

MR: Well there you go.

HP: But no we just, well we've been together 30 years.

MR: So this has been worked out long ago, right?

HP: Yeah, just trial and errors over the years, so we just go and do it. Yeah that's the way it works.

MR: Well the last time I saw you guys was a pretty nice situation on that cruise ship.

HP: Yeah.

MR: It's interesting, some venues have shrunk for jazz, others have opened up.

HP: Yeah.

MR: I guess that's probably a pretty good gig to get, those kinds of things.

HP: Yeah. Because we'll be going on The Norway in October. We've been going on that for the last five or six years. That's been great.

MR: A pretty educated audience too.

HP: Oh well the audience is there just for that. So if you're going to spend your cruise money, you're going to get your money's worth. No it's a great cruise too because they have Meet the Artists Series, autograph sessions, record sales sessions, and jam sessions, the whole thing, so it's great.

MR: Do you get to bring your own band?

HP: You get to bring your own band. That's very important. Yeah. So you'll see it all — everybody doing their thing, the way they do it, and then you'll catch a lot of jam sessions.

MR: Now I know musicians around here, including myself, have in our book, we have a list. If a gig comes up you say now who can I get on drums, and you go down and make your first choice. Is it the same for you? Do you have a circle of people that you call on or do you have the same people all the time?

HP: Well in the recording studio I have a circle of people, because you have artists considerations too, the artists that you're producing. But I have a regular band, same guys, the piano player's been with us about ten years, ten or twelve years. So no, the same guys, yeah.

MR: That's great. There's a lot to be said for having some arrangements worked out and having a sound.

HP: Yeah we've got a sound. All by trial and error. Yeah I like to wing it. We wing it.

MR: Do you write out a set before you go up on stage?

HP: No.

MR: You like read the audience?

HP: Yeah. I couldn't follow it anyways. No it just rolls out, whatever it is.

MR: Do you see a good future for this music in general, for jazz? I see so much publicity about it but I don't see it transferred to live venues.

HP: Well I see a future, I really do. Because I think there's going to be I should say evolution but a revolution. You see part of it now would be kids starting the swing dancing things, suddenly you're pushing bands back. Even if it's Glenn Miller, Benny Goodman, and all those people, Count Basie and Duke Ellington, listen to those regularly as kids are starting to listen to that, in that swing dance situation. So then you'll have groups, college groups, having swing bands. And it will evolve, it will go all the way around full circle again. And yeah I see a future, because I think that, as I said before, the dance will come back, as we see it is. And they should take a cue from Lincoln Center and the response that they had with it.

MR: So people can get involved, as you said.

HP: Yeah you've got to get people back into it. That's what you've got to do.

MR: I want to see if I can find this particular tune that I just loved the beginning of, that has the Houston Person sound down. Let me see if I've got it. I don't got it. There it is.

HP: A Houston Person sound, oh. Let me hear this so I can learn it.

[audio interlude: "As Time Goes By" from the CD "Why Not"]

MR: That is romantic as all get out.

HP: I get a lot of calls about that song.

MR: Now you did something at the end of this tune too, do you recall? The last A [section]?

HP: No.

MR: No you don't? Let me see if I can find it. I hope I don't make a liar out of myself. It must have been right at the end, you did this very cool modulation, right at the end of that tune.

HP: Oh yeah?

MR: Yeah, you're going to have to listen to yourself now, because it was neat, believe me.

HP: Okay, I will.

MR: You took the last A and you went like, I don't know, it was nice, real nice.

HP: Okay, okay. Gee. Yeah, I've got to listen to that.

MR: Well is there's anything else that you'd like to ask me before we wrap up here?

HP: Yeah, give me a gig. Am I coming back in April? That's what I want to know.

MR: That's what you want to know. Well I look forward to seeing you tomorrow night on the stage, and if I get up and start dancing I hope—

HP: I'm going to play something slow and pretty for you, and you can dance. Are you going to dance for me now?

MR: You know it's funny I don't dance much. Usually I'm on the playing end of things, but I do like to move to the music.

HP: Well I don't dance. I never learned. I'm a little shy too I guess.

MR: Yeah I know I can tell.

HP: Yeah, but getting out on the floor man. But I love to see people dance. That really gets to me.

MR: Well the stories are, there are many stories on how fellows like Basie and everything learned from the dancers what tempos worked.

HP: Yeah. You do. They'll give it to you. Yeah I love it.

MR: Well it's been a pleasure again talking with you.

HP: Well the same here. It's always a pleasure being here in academia, the halls of academia. I'm really having a ball. I really enjoy it up here though.

MR: We're glad to have you.

HP: And see our young people develop, and they're in good hands.

MR: Right. Appreciate that, and I'll see you tomorrow night.

HP: I hope so.

MR: Okay. Get me a ticket on the Norway if you would.

HP: Is that on camera?

MR: That's on camera. Okay, see you soon.

HP: Hey, thank you, thank you.